

131 Matthew

The tax collector who left his table to follow Jesus and threw a party for sinners.

Matthew, also called Levi, collected taxes by the Sea of Galilee, probably at Capernaum. To most Jews of his day, that made him a collaborator and a cheat. Jesus walked past his tax booth and said, "Follow me." Matthew left it all and followed. Then he threw a great feast so his fellow tax collectors could meet Jesus too. When the Pharisees objected, Jesus answered that the sick, not the healthy, need a doctor. No Gospel records a word Matthew spoke, yet the church has long linked his name with the first Gospel.

At a glance

Name	Matthew, probably "gift of the LORD"; also called Levi (Mark 2:14; Luke 5:27)
Family	Son of Alphaeus (Mark 2:14)
Work	Publican (tax collector), probably at Capernaum (Matthew 9:9)
Main passages	Matthew 9:9–13; Mark 2:14–17; Luke 5:27–32
Among the Twelve	Matthew 10:3; Mark 3:18; Luke 6:15; Acts 1:13
Writing	Traditionally the Gospel of Matthew; authorship is debated
Later life	Not recorded in Scripture; see Tradition on page 4

"And as Jesus passed forth from thence, he saw a man, named Matthew, sitting at the receipt of custom: and he saith unto him, Follow me. And he arose, and followed him."

Matthew 9:9, KJV

The life of Matthew

Dates are approximate (AD). Jesus' ministry is dated c. AD 27/28–30 in this study.
Scripture does not give Matthew's age.

- c. AD 28

Capernaum

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Called from the tax booth

Walking by the Sea of Galilee, Jesus sees Levi the son of Alphaeus sitting at the receipt of custom. At the words "Follow me," he leaves everything and follows. *Mark 2:13–14; Luke 5:27–28*
- c. AD 28

His own house

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Hosts a great feast

Levi makes a great feast for Jesus, and many tax collectors and sinners sit down to eat with him and his disciples. *Luke 5:29; Matthew 9:10*
- c. AD 28

His own house

●

Hears Jesus defend him

The Pharisees ask why Jesus eats with publicans and sinners. Jesus answers that he came to call sinners to repentance. *Matthew 9:11–13*
- c. AD 28

On a mountain

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Chosen as an apostle

Jesus names the Twelve. In Matthew's Gospel the list calls him "Matthew the publican," keeping his old label. *Matthew 10:2–4; Luke 6:13–16*
- c. AD 30

Jerusalem

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Waits in the upper room

After the ascension Matthew is with the other apostles and the women, praying and waiting for the Spirit. *Acts 1:13–14*

Group notes

Key activities

Mark and Luke call him *Levi*, while Matthew's Gospel calls him *Matthew*. Most readers take these as two names for one man, as with Simon and Peter.

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- 1 Sat at the receipt of custom.** He worked in a trade that made him an outsider among his people. *Matthew 9:9*
 - 2 Left everything.** Luke says he "left all, rose up, and followed him." *Luke 5:27-28*
 - 3 Opened his home.** He made a great feast so other tax collectors could meet Jesus. *Luke 5:29*
 - 4 Saw Jesus defend sinners.** Jesus answered the critics, "They that be whole need not a physician, but they that are sick." *Matthew 9:12*
 - 5 Heard mercy taught.** Jesus sent the critics to learn what Hosea meant: "I will have mercy, and not sacrifice." *Matthew 9:13*
 - 6 Joined the Twelve.** He was listed among the apostles, still named as a publican. *Matthew 10:3*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Matthew.

Old Testament

Hosea 6:6	Mercy, not sacrifice; quoted by Jesus at Matthew's feast (Matthew 9:13)
Echo: Matthew 1:22; 2:15; 4:14	His Gospel's deep interest in fulfilled prophecy

New Testament

Matthew 9:9–13; Mark 2:14–17; Luke 5:27–32	His call and feast
Matthew 10:3; Mark 3:18; Luke 6:15; Acts 1:13	Listed among the Twelve
Echo: Luke 19:1–10; 18:9–14	Zacchaeus, and the publican who went home justified
Tradition	Papias (in Eusebius) credits Matthew with this Gospel; many scholars debate the link

For discussion

- Observe:* What did Matthew do right after he left his tax booth (Luke 5:28–29)?
- Understand:* Why did the Pharisees object to Jesus eating with publicans, and what did Jesus mean by his answer (Matthew 9:11–13)?
- Apply:* Matthew's first act as a disciple was to throw a party for his old friends. Who could you invite to meet Jesus over a meal?
- Apply:* Is there anyone you have written off as too far gone? How might you show them mercy this week?